

LIVING WITH THE
GHOST OF SAM

BOOK THREE

TWO OUT OF THREE
AIN'T BAD

DEREK DEVON

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First Edition, 2026 Self-published by the author.

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To Howard Stern,
who put Sam on the air when the networks wouldn't touch him, laughed at
the parts everyone else apologized for, and never stopped saying his name
after 1992.

And to Craig Gass, whose Sam impression on Howard's show was so
dead-on it bordered on a séance — piss-your-pants funny, every single
time.

Every legend needs a witness. Sam had the King of All Media... and an
encore.

THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

Book Three — Two Out of Three Ain't Bad

Book Four — Last Laugh

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CHAPTER ONE

THE WITCH ON THE GRAVEL ROAD

You want to know the thing about small towns, kid? Everybody says they moved there for the quiet. Nobody — and I mean NOBODY — reads the fine print about what the quiet costs. OH OH OHHHH!

It began, as so many terrible mornings do, with a tornado.

Not a real one, of course. Reality had been on flexible terms with Ravenscrest for some time now, and this particular tornado belonged to a dream — or a memory, or a broadcast, depending on who in town you asked. Inside the funnel, pedaling with the grim municipal determination of a woman late for a zoning hearing, rode Miss Almira Gulch of Kansas, basket on the back, hat pinned against the wind, exactly as generations of children had watched her ride before the picture went to color and she went to green.

Except that as the wind turned her, as the bicycle stretched and warped and became a broomstick, the face beneath the hat wasn't Miss Gulch's anymore.

It was Linda Rhodes's.

She rode the broom out of the tornado in a long banking arc, through cloud and gray morning light, down and down toward a ribbon of gravel road where a silver Mercedes was making its patient way toward a mansion that had recently decided it liked its new owners. The witch and the car converged. There was a puff of

theatrical smoke, the kind stage managers order by the crate, and then there was only the Mercedes, and behind the wheel sat Linda Rhodes with a green face and a hooked nose, checking her lipstick in the visor mirror as though nothing about the commute had been unusual.

High above her, on the widow's walk at the very top of Ravenscrest, thunder banged twice — loud, showy, entirely unnecessary, which was very much the house style.

And up through the floorboards of the widow's walk, rising slowly the way a stage elevator lifts a headliner, came the Ghost of Sam.

He was dressed, if that was the word, in Angus Young's purple school shorts and nothing else above the waist, except for the beret — always the beret — from which two small fake red devil horns protruded at jaunty angles. His fingers were already working the opening guitar solo of AC/DC's "Highway to Hell," and beside him, materializing with the courtesy of a man who never missed a cue in life and saw no reason to start now, stood the ghost of Bon Scott himself, ready on the vocal.

Below, the Mercedes rolled on. Green-faced Linda drove with both hands at ten and two, because whatever else Linda Rhodes might be — and the list of possibilities was lengthening by the day — she was a careful driver.

Above, two dead men played the greatest arena on earth — an audience of gulls, a chimney, and one profoundly patient mansion. Sam threw his head back on the high notes. Bon delivered the vocal with the ragged joy of a man who had been waiting decades for exactly this booking. The thunder kept time, which was more than could be said for most rhythm sections, living or otherwise.

Morning came down the front of Ravenscrest the way everything came to Ravenscrest — deliberately, and with a sense of staging —

past gargoyles that may or may not have been tapping along, through the glass of a second-floor window, and into a room where Derek Kinison and Nancy Hammond slept in their underwear on sleeping bags, blissfully unaware that they were the opening act.

On the roof, Sam hit the song's famous finish, arms wide, horns gleaming.

Somewhere in the house, something applauded.

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CHAPTER TWO

BREAKFAST IS SERVED

Morning light filtered through the Victorian windows, gentle and golden and entirely innocent of the night before. The storm had passed. Derek and Nancy slept peacefully on their sleeping bags, which now rested — and neither of them had any memory of arranging this — atop a huge ornate four-poster bed in the master bedroom just off the study. Sam's beret hung on a nearby coat hook like a soldier at ease.

The room itself had undergone a quiet transformation. The cobwebs were gone. The dust was gone. The whole chamber had the scrubbed, hopeful look of about 1955 — the wallpaper brighter, the wood gleaming, the air smelling faintly of lemon oil and optimism, as though the room had spent the night remembering its best decade and decided to wear it. On the wall hung a photograph of Mr. and Mrs. Blackwood, both of them smiling in a way that suggested they knew something.

Later, Derek would try to reconstruct when, exactly, the four-poster bed had entered the equation. They had gone to sleep on the floor. He was nearly sure of it. But the house had a way of editing the previous night on your behalf, smoothing the rough cut, and he was learning that the residents' best move was to accept the final version and not ask for the dailies.

The pipe organ, several rooms and one floor away, began to play a gentle morning melody.

Derek stirred. He opened his eyes and took inventory, which was becoming his standard operating procedure at Ravencrest: two empty wine bottles; Nancy curled against him with his arm draped over her; and, in the corner, a small red light blinking from an old

dumb waiter.

He extracted his arm from over his wife with the delicacy of a bomb technician, replacing it with a fold of sleeping bag, and padded across the room in his underwear.

"That wasn't lit up last night," he whispered to himself.

He opened the dumb waiter door.

Inside sat a silver serving tray bearing a steaming pot of fresh-brewed coffee, a small jug of milk, a small bowl of sugar, two perfectly baked scones, a single red rose in a crystal vase, and a folded note on which someone had written, in elegant script, *Welcome Home*.

Derek stood there a moment, weighing the established options — run screaming, or pour the coffee — and, being a Kinison, chose the coffee.

There was, he decided, a threshold somewhere in every haunting, a line past which terror gives way to logistics. A house that moans at you at three in the morning is a horror. A house that has your breakfast ready by seven, with the milk in a separate jug and a rose in a crystal vase, is — whatever else it may be — a better host than most of his relatives. He carried the tray to the side table near their sleeping bags. The aroma filled the room like a rumor.

"Nance... wake up..."

"Five more minutes," Nancy mumbled.

"Rise and shine, beautiful."

She stirred. Sniffed. One eye opened. "Is that... French roast?"

Derek picked up the note. "Looks like someone's happy we won."

Nancy reached for her coffee, still half asleep, and as she did the note unfolded itself in Derek's hands. He watched the handwriting change before his eyes, elegant script melting into something looser,

louder, unmistakably familiar:

Comedy needs a home. You two will do nicely. OH OH OHHHH!

Outside, far down the gravel drive, a silver Mercedes was pulling up to the front of the mansion. Inside, the pipe organ segued into a jaunty rendition of "Morning Has Broken," which was either a hymn or a warning.

At the front door, Linda Rhodes tried the handle and found it locked, which appeared to alarm her more than a locked door should alarm a realtor. She produced a ring of keys and tried a couple. The door declined all of them.

Upstairs, the pounding began — echoing through the mansion with the urgency of a process server.

Derek and Nancy exchanged a look, and then the voice came from outside.

"Mr. Kinison! Ms. Hammond! We need to talk! The town council is meeting in an hour!"

Nancy took a bite of scone. Her eyes went wide.

"Oh my god, these are still warm... and delicious."

Derek went to the window, opened it, and stuck his head out into the morning. "Morning, Linda. We'll be right down. Meet you in the great room in five."

"Congratulations, folks," Linda called up. "Looks like you won the contest."

Before she'd finished the sentence, the front door swung open by itself. Linda regarded it the way one regards a dog that has learned a new and unwelcome trick.

Derek closed the window, returned to bed, and claimed a cup of coffee and the other scone. "How did you sleep?"

"Actually, wonderfully," Nancy said through a semi-mouthful of scone, "after you did your thang." The grin she added was not the grin of a woman traumatized by her real estate.

Derek smiled, leaned over, and kissed her cheek. "It's what I do best." He paused. "I can't believe we made it through the night. I was sure we would end up swinging from some hangman's noose in the front lobby."

"Oh God, Derek, you're not serious, are you?"

"No. Just needed to jolt you to life. We have to meet Linda downstairs in... like three and a half minutes."

Nancy looked at the coffee, the scones, the rose, the note from a dead man welcoming them home, and then at her husband, calculating — and Derek watched her arrive at the same conclusion he had at the dumb waiter: that at some point in the last forty-eight hours, the two of them had crossed from *people this is happening to* into *people this is happening with*, and there was no visible road back.

She drained her cup and stood. "Three and a half minutes. Fine. But I'm finishing that scone in the car."

Somewhere below them, the pipe organ finished its hymn with a flourish, and the house — clean, warm, smug — settled in to watch its new owners scramble.



CHAPTER THREE

DRESS TO KILL

Linda paced before the grand fireplace in the great room, checking her phone with the focus of a woman monitoring several fires at once. The pipe organ, apparently unable to resist an entrance, played a few soft bars of "The Girl from Ipanema" as Derek and Nancy came in — still in yesterday's clothes, and yet looking surprisingly refreshed, as though the house had laundered them in their sleep. Which, at this point, neither of them was prepared to rule out.

"The council wasn't supposed to meet until next week," Linda said, "but after last night's... performance..."

"You mean the LA couple's hasty exit?" Nancy said.

Linda consulted her phone. "They've posted six videos already. Three million views and counting. It appears this place is famous again."

Again. Derek filed the word away. Everything in this town came with an *again* attached — the house was famous again, the show must go on again, traditions were being kept alive that no one would name. It was like moving into a sentence whose first half had been spoken thirty years before you arrived.

The pipe organ hit a rimshot. Nobody acknowledged it. Acknowledging it only encouraged it.

"Let me guess — they're suing," Derek said. "I knew they would be poor losers."

"Actually... their lawyers refused the case. Something about not wanting to anger... certain parties."

"I would have guessed they'd be looking for a divorce attorney and not a litigator, after what we heard last night," Derek said.

"Besides, we won fair and square," Nancy said. "Rules are the rules, right, Linda?"

"Yes, Nancy, you folks won, and now we need to focus on getting you down to the Town Council meeting ASAP."

Thunder rumbled in the distance. The sky, visible through every window in the room, was flawlessly clear. This discrepancy bothered exactly one of the three people present, and she was pretending it didn't.

"You'll need to change," Linda said. "The council is... particular."

"Why do we need to see the Town Council?" Derek asked.

"Well, there may be a small clause in the deed that pertains to any buyer of the property must be approved by the Town..." Linda's mouth performed a small correction. "I mean, Town Council."

"I'm sorry, Linda, but what you see is what they'll have to get," Nancy said. "We didn't bring a change of clothes."

A creaking sound answered her. Everyone turned. The dumb waiter light was blinking again, accompanied by the squeak of a wheel somewhere in the walls, patiently hauling.

Nancy walked over and opened it. Inside sat an antique overnight bag, and inside the bag, freshly pressed clothes. A note lay on top: *Dress to kill!* — S

"There you go, problem solved," Linda said, pretending with tremendous professionalism not to have noticed any of it. "I'll wait in the foyer."

"I thought last night pushed the boundaries on my sanity," Nancy said, "but this just gets weirder and weirder."

"If you think this is weird," Derek said, peering into the bag, "you better be prepared for wearing some 1950s underwear."

Linda exited. Derek pulled out a pressed suit, a shirt, a tie, and the underwear he had just mentioned, holding the last item at a distance appropriate to its vintage.

Nancy lifted out a perfect black dress and examined it. "Okay, this is getting weird. I'm definitely keeping my own undies on."

"Getting?" Derek said.

He held the suit up against himself. It would fit. He knew it would fit the way you know the sun will rise — not because he'd checked the measurements, but because the entity providing the wardrobe had demonstrated a thoroughness about their comfort that was starting to feel less like hospitality and more like stage management. Breakfast, hot water, formal wear. They were being produced. Fed, cleaned, costumed, and delivered to the venue on schedule.

Dress to kill, the note said. He very much hoped that was just an expression.

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The master bathroom had produced hot water from somewhere, and steam from the shower still fogged the glass. Nancy applied makeup at the ornate mirror while Derek fought his tie beside her.

"I would like to know when we got hot water working," she said. "What do you think this council meeting is really about?"

"Besides welcoming the new neighbors?"

The mirror cleared itself.

It didn't defog the way mirrors do, in patches, from the middle out. It cleared the way a curtain rises. And in the reflection behind them, adjusting his beret with the critical eye of a man who had

opened for legends, stood Sam.

"Oh oh ohhhh! Kids, in this town, 'council meeting' is code for 'command performance'..."

Derek and Nancy spun around.

No one there. Just steam, and tile, and the particular silence of a room that has recently contained a dead comedian.

When they turned back, the mirror had fogged over again — except for one clear spot, where someone had written: *Break-a-leg!*

"Did you say something?" Derek asked, with the last, threadbare hope of a man clinging to the rational explanation.

Nancy stared at the writing. "I think... we're about to find out what kind of show they're expecting."

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CHAPTER FOUR

EVERY DAY IS OPEN MIC NIGHT

Linda waited by the door in the foyer, typing rapidly on her phone. She looked up as Derek and Nancy descended the grand staircase, and whatever she had been about to type, she abandoned it, because they looked — there was no other word for it — impeccable. The house did good work.

"Perfect," Linda said. "Though..." Her eye caught Derek's collar sitting askew. She crossed to him and fixed it with an added smile, a small maternal gesture from a woman who had, some hours earlier, flown a broomstick into her own car.

As she turned to Nancy, a beret appeared on Derek's head.

It did not fall from anywhere. It did not arrive. It was simply, suddenly, present — and Derek, feeling something odd on his head, raised both hands and felt the wool.

"Now that is definitely super weird," he said.

Linda turned back, saw the beret, and sighed the sigh of a professional whose listing kept editorializing. "I suppose some things are non-negotiable."

They took two cars. Linda led the way down an old cart path through the woods, a route that existed on no map Derek had consulted — no GPS had ever suggested it, no satellite had apparently photographed it — and yet here it was, graded and dry, threading between trees old enough to have opinions. The morning light came down through the canopy in long amber shafts, and Derek drove through them one after another, light, shadow, light, shadow, like frames of film advancing.

"You know what's strange?" Nancy said, watching the woods slide past.

"You're going to have to narrow that down considerably."

"This road. It feels like it was built for exactly this. Getting from the house to the town. Nothing else. No driveways, no turnoffs. Like the two of them are..." She searched for the word. "Connected."

Derek said nothing, because he suspected she was right, and because agreeing out loud to things like that felt, lately, like signing documents he hadn't read.

They emerged at the edge of town through an ornate gate that stood open in a manner suggesting it had been expecting them.

Through the front windows of the car, they saw the townsfolk gathering in the square. Many carried signs — hand-lettered, careful, the work of people who had known this day was coming with more lead time than the people it was about. WELCOME HOME KINISONS, read one, which was warm, and thoughtful, and raised the immediate question of how a town they'd arrived in days ago had settled on the word *home*. THE SHOW MUST GO ON, read another, and something about that one made the back of Derek's neck prickle. It wasn't a welcome. It was a policy.

"I thought this was a council meeting," he said.

"Look how they're all dressed," Nancy said.

Linda parked. Derek parked beside her. They all got out into a square that smelled of coffee and sea air and anticipation.

It was, on its face, a postcard: brick storefronts, striped awnings, a bandstand, the fog coming in off the water in slow silver sheets. The Last Laugh Diner had its lights on. Somewhere down the block would be Earl's station, and the outdoor supply store, and the pub, and the church, the whole modest inventory of a coastal town — except that this morning the whole modest inventory had emptied

itself into the square, and every soul in it had turned, in the same moment, to look at Derek Kinison.

Not hostile. Worse. *Expectant*.

"Looks like some Comic-Con type festival," Derek said.

"In this town, Mr. Kinison," Linda said, "every day is open mic night."

A manual pipe organ stationed in the square — because of course this town had a manual pipe organ stationed in the square — struck up the opening notes of "There's No Business Like Show Business" as they stepped out of the laneway.

"*Oh oh ohhhh! Time to give 'em hell, kid!*" said a voice that came from nowhere and everywhere and one specific dead relative.

"Did you hear—" Derek began.

"Yes, I did," Nancy said, finishing the sentence the way ten years of marriage teaches you to. "Weird square now."

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CHAPTER FIVE

THE INITIATION

As Derek, Nancy, and Linda walked toward the stage at the center of the square, a voice floated out of the crowd — pitched perfectly, lovingly, straight out of *The Ghost and Mr. Chicken*:

"That a boy, Derek!"

Derek did not stop to find out which townspeople had delivered it. Somehow he knew that if he turned around, they would all be looking somewhere else.

Fog was rolling in from the coast, unhurried, atmospheric, on cue. The crowd parted before them like the Red Sea, and as they passed, townspeople on either side tipped invisible berets — a whole choreography of respect for a hat most of them weren't wearing.

"Derek," Nancy whispered. "Are they all wearing black?"

They were. Every citizen was dressed in dark formal wear, as if attending a show... or a funeral. In this town, Derek was beginning to suspect, the distinction was mostly a matter of scheduling.

"The prodigal comedian returns!"

Earl emerged from the crowd, and Earl had dressed for the occasion. He wore a vintage comedy club doorman's uniform, brass buttons polished, complete with a badge that read THE LAUGH ASYLUM — EST. 1992.

"Earl? What's going on?"

"Just keeping the tradition alive, son," Earl said, with the cryptic serenity of a man who sold both gasoline and fishing tackle and had seen things. "Your uncle would be proud."

He fell into step beside them for a few paces, badge gleaming, and Derek noticed the date on it again. *Est. 1992*. Not the year the club opened — Derek was fairly sure The Laugh Asylum went back to the eighties. The year, then, of something else. The year everything in this town seemed to be established, buried, taped, or begun.

Earl peeled off at the Town Hall steps, taking up a position by the doors like a man resuming a post he had held for a very long time, and waved them through.

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The Town Hall was not your typical municipal building. Municipal buildings smell of linoleum and toner; this one smelled of velvet and old applause. It was a restored vaudeville theatre, and someone had restored it with love: red velvet seats in curving rows, ornate mouldings, gilt trim catching the light, a dome ceiling painted with clouds that looked suspiciously more three-dimensional than paint should allow. And most surprising of all, a full stage — bare except for a single microphone stand, standing in a spotlight like a gallows with better acoustics.

Derek had sat through a thousand meetings in rooms designed to make people smaller. This room had been designed to make one person, standing in one spot, enormous. He was very much afraid he knew which spot.

The town council sat in a raised box above the floor, arranged like theatre critics, which, Derek would come to understand, was exactly what they were. Presiding at their center was MAYOR FLORENCE BLACKWOOD — seventies, regal, with a face that Derek couldn't place and eyes that he could. Dr. Blackwood's eyes. The eyes from the portrait, from the study, from a house full of things that watched.

"Derek Kinison and Nancy Hammond," the mayor said. "Please approach."

They walked down the aisle. Every seat was filled. Every single one. Betty from the diner caught Derek's eye and gave him a thumbs up, which under the circumstances was worth roughly a Nobel Prize.

Linda took her place beside the council box and addressed the room. "As property manager of Ravencrest Manor, I present the winners of last night's... residency challenge. Mr. Derek Kinison and his lovely wife, Nancy."

The entire townsfolk erupted — cheering, clapping, a wall of warmth so sudden and total that Derek felt it in his chest. It went on. And on. Somewhere near the two-minute mark, Mayor Blackwood took up a wooden gavel and banged it.

"Enough, enough!"

The room settled instantly, the way rooms settle for someone.

"The terms were unusual," the mayor said, "but the outcome... predictable."

Thunder rumbled. Through the dome ceiling, the sky remained insolently clear.

"There's the matter of the initiation," said Councilman Jones — sixties, serious, with the delivery of a man announcing an audit.

Nancy looked at Derek. "Initiation?"

"Every Ravencrest owner must prove their worth," Mayor Blackwood said. "It's tradition. Not to mention it's part of the deed. Isn't that right, Malcolm?"

She turned to her right, toward a leathery-faced older man in a top hat, who responded with a single nod that carried the weight of notarization.

The spotlight on the microphone stand intensified. Derek would have sworn no one touched a switch.

"You want me to... perform?"

"Oh oh ohhhh!" whispered a voice in Derek's ear, intimate as a secret.

"Show time, kid!"

The beret adjusted itself on his head to the perfect angle. Derek felt a familiar energy building — the same current he'd felt in the boardroom the day everything popped, except this time the room wanted it.

"On April 9th, 1992," Mayor Blackwood said, "your uncle gave his last performance. Not in Las Vegas, as the world believes, but right here. On this very stage. It was the greatest comedy show ever. As is the tradition, in order to receive the title to Ravenscrest, you must perform your uncle's final set... exactly."

The word *exactly* landed in the theatre and sat there.

Derek stood in the aisle and felt the room recalibrate around him. Fifteen years of corporate life had taught him to read a negotiation, and every instinct he owned was reporting the same finding: this was not a negotiation. There was no counteroffer coming, no term sheet, no reasonable-minds clause. The mayor had stated a fact the way you state the boiling point of water, and several hundred people in funeral formal wear were waiting to see whether the new element would combust.

His uncle's final set. Word for word — presumably gesture for gesture, scream for scream. A performance Derek had never seen, delivered by a man Derek had barely been allowed to know, on a stage where — if the mayor was to be believed — the world's account of Sam Kinison's last night on earth was simply wrong.

Derek looked at Nancy, then at the mayor. "I'm sorry, Mayor. I never really watched one of my Uncle Sam's performances growing

up. He passed when I was around five, and my folks didn't think it was age-appropriate for me to see him. I watched him in *Back to School*, and watched a bunch of YouTube stuff over the years — although I did once see him preach when I was a kid."

The entire place went quiet. Not polite-quiet. Vacuum-quiet.

The town council formed a huddle in their box, robed shoulders drawing together, and began to discuss the situation in murmurs that carried nowhere.

Nancy found Derek's hand and squeezed it, and the two of them stood in the aisle of a packed vaudeville theatre watching a municipal scrum decide their real estate.

It took about three minutes. Then Mayor Blackwood stood, and the entire town stood with her, several hundred people rising in a single rustle of black formal wear.

"Due to the somewhat unique circumstances we find ourselves in today, we will formally adjourn this meeting for one week. We will reconvene here in seven days, and Mr. Kinison will return and deliver the required performance as dictated by our town's charter and the deed to the property. The property shall remain in escrow until such time as Mr. Kinison meets the performance requirement — or the property defaults to the town in perpetuity."

The gavel swung. The town began to rise and file out into the square, chatting pleasantly, as though they had just approved a new crosswalk. That was the part that unsettled Derek most — not the terms, not the escrow, not even the word *perpetuity*, which no one had ever used in his presence with good news attached. It was the pleasantness. Several hundred people had just watched a man be sentenced to comedy, and they were discussing lunch.

Linda made her way over. "Well, I think that went as well as it could have under the circumstances."

"Linda," Derek said, "I think we need to have a little heart-to-heart about what the hell is going on."

"Derek, this just keeps getting weirder and weirder," Nancy said, "to the point the gallery and your PowerPoint is looking pretty damn good."

"Please, folks, don't let this minor issue spoil your victory," Linda said. "This is merely a minor formality that I am sure Derek will handle like a pro. After all — he is a Kinison."

And before Derek or Nancy could get another word out, Linda turned and walked away in what could only be described as a hurry.

Across the emptying theatre, in the background where backgrounds keep their secrets, Malcolm Thorne consulted a brass pocket watch. Its hands spun rapidly forward, then backward, and settled on 3:33. He exchanged a knowing look with Mayor Blackwood.

"Time moves differently when the mansion chooses," he said quietly, to her and to no one.

The watch's ticking seemed to grow louder as a couple dozen townsfolk closed in around Derek and Nancy, grabbing their hands, shaking them, one after another after another: "Welcome to our wonderful town. We are so excited to have you part of our wonderful family."

They said it warmly. They said it sincerely. They said it, Derek noticed somewhere around the fifteenth handshake, in *exactly the same words* — every one of them, wonderful town, wonderful family, the phrasing identical down to the excitement, like a congregation reciting a response it had known since childhood. He shook hands and smiled and filed that away in the drawer that was rapidly filling with things he filed away.

The pipe organ started playing by itself. It chose "The Phantom of the Opera," which nobody appeared to find inappropriate.

Earl appeared at Derek's shoulder and tapped it once.

"The house chose you, son," he said. "Now you have to choose it back."

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CHAPTER SIX

THE COUNCIL BEHIND THE DOOR

Linda walked alone down a dark Town Hall corridor lined with portraits of past council members, generations of them, their painted eyes doing the thing painted eyes do in houses like this town. She paused at a mirror. Her hand rose, almost involuntarily, and touched her head — the place where, beneath the wig, two horn-like stumps protruded from her skull.

Then she continued, to an ancient oak door marked with faint symbols that seemed to shift in the light, the way words shift when you try to read them in a dream.

She traced one of the symbols with a fingertip. The door swung open silently.

The private chamber beyond was Victorian, dark wood panels drinking the light. Sun filtered through stained glass windows depicting the masks of comedy and tragedy — this town committed to a theme — and laid pools of colored light across the floor, red where tragedy fell, gold where comedy did, the room itself divided between the two the way its business always had been.

Mayor Blackwood stood at an ornate podium. The other council members sat at a crescent-shaped table with ancient ledgers lying open before them — the kind of ledgers in which things are not recorded so much as bound.

Malcolm Thorne — eighties, leather-faced, top hat still on — studied his brass pocket watch, which was now, unhurriedly, ticking backward.

"The time approaches," he said. "The house has chosen."

Diana Ravenscroft — forties, striking, silver streaks running through dark hair — traced patterns on a tablet computer whose case was etched with symbols nobody at Apple had approved. "But is he ready? The mansion's energy readings are... unprecedented."

Mayor Blackwood removed her gloves, deliberately, one finger at a time — revealing faint silvery markings on her skin that seemed to shift in the light, cousin to the symbols on the door.

"The Kinison blood runs true," she said. "But this one brings something new. Something... digital."

James Porter — sixties, wire-rimmed glasses, the town historian — consulted an ancient leather-bound book while glancing, in the same breath, at a modern laptop, a man bilingual in centuries. "According to the records, Jonathan Rhodes was working on something beyond our understanding. Called it 'Project Comedian.'"

"That bloody house has been the bane of our existence since Rhodes implemented that filter system." The mayor tossed her gloves onto a table with genuine venom. "This was never meant to have a filter on its power. It had worked perfectly for generations without any bloody filter. If these ancient ruins wanted a filter, they would have built one from the beginning."

Her markings pulsed briefly with light. Outside, thunder rumbled its agreement.

Malcolm adjusted his top hat. "Rhodes. He never truly understood what he built. He was a damn goody two-shoes, if you ask me." His voice curdled into sarcasm. "Let's build a filter that only lets the pure through."

"These readings..." Diana was frowning at her tablet. "They're like nothing in our grimoires. Almost like it's... learning."

"Like Linda's transformation," Malcolm said, and his hand drifted absently to his own horn-like stumps. "The mansion's power grows."

"The mansion chose them both," Mayor Blackwood said. "Just like it has been doing for two hundred years. Derek and Nancy. But which one does it truly want?"

Porter looked up from his book. "Perhaps the mansion will reveal the answer at the performance. As long as Kinison brings that mic with him, they will have no idea what we are planning. Some of us will recall the last performance of Derek's uncle. Before — you know what... the sacrifice that failed."

Thunder crashed. The lights flickered, and for one long moment their shadows on the wall were wrong — distorted, elongated, suggesting robes and ritual garb that none of them, at this particular meeting, happened to be wearing.

"Until then, we observe. We guide. We wait." Mayor Blackwood's voice was calm as a ledger. "We call our friend with the cube."

Through the stained glass, in fractured colored light, Derek and Nancy could be seen walking to their car, unaware of being watched, unaware of most things, holding hands.

"And if he fails the performance?" Diana asked.

Mayor Blackwood pulled her gloves back on, finger by finger, the silvery markings disappearing beneath kid leather and civic respectability.

"Then the mansion will have its sacrifice. One way... or another. It always does!"

The brass pocket watch chimed — an unnatural sound, struck from no hour that appears on clocks — and its hands went on spinning backward.

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CHAPTER SEVEN

THE READINGS CAN'T BE RIGHT

Linda drove the coastal road with her wig slightly askew, which for Linda Rhodes was the equivalent of open weeping.

The ocean did what the ocean does — vast, gray-green, magnificently indifferent to real estate — and on any other afternoon she might have found it settling. Not today. Today the road unspooled ahead of her, and behind her the town receded with its council and its charter and its seven-day clock, and in between sat Linda, a woman balanced for thirty years on the exact seam between two worlds, feeling the stitching start to give.

Her tablet chimed. She glanced at it, glanced again, and pulled into a hidden turnout overlooking the ocean — one of those gravel half-moons that exist so people can admire the view or quietly fall apart, depending on the day.

The screen read: MANSION POWER CONSUMPTION: 300% ABOVE NORMAL.

Linda stared at it for a moment. Then she reached into the glove compartment and removed an ancient leather-bound book, its cover worked with metallic symbols that matched, exactly, the ones etched into her tablet case. Two devices, three centuries apart, wearing the same jewelry.

"The readings can't be right," she said to herself, to the ocean, to whatever was listening. Something was always listening.

She opened the book. The pages were split down a strange middle — handwritten spells on one side, dense computer code on the other, marginalia crossing between them like footpaths worn between two farms. Some of the ink was iron-gall brown, old

enough to have faded into the paper; some of it was ballpoint; one recent entry appeared to have been made with a gel pen in a shade of teal, because even the custodians of ancient mysteries eventually run out of the good pens. The recent entries were energy measurements from Ravencrest, spanning decades, in a succession of hands — as though the book had been passed along a chain of keepers, each one adding their numbers and their worries and handing both to the next.

She flipped through, and headings surfaced and sank:

Rhodes Project Implementation.

Sam Kinison: Final Performance Analysis.

Quantum Integration Protocol.

The Protocol.

Thunder rumbled. Linda looked up. Storm clouds were gathering over Ravencrest — over Ravencrest specifically, a private weather system convened above one roof, while everywhere else the sky went on being July.

The tablet chimed again: UNAUTHORIZED ACCESS ATTEMPT — LAB 1D.

Her hand went to the horn stumps beneath the wig. "No... they can't find it yet."

She started the car — and froze, because the tablet had one more message for her, and the tablet delivered it in plain block capitals with no signature block, no header, nothing but:

HELLO LINDA. WE NEED TO TALK. — AB

Linda's hands shook as she put the car in gear. And in her rearview mirror, for the length of one heartbeat, Jonathan Rhodes sat in the back seat — composed, patient, waiting.

She turned to look. No one there, of course.

There is never anyone there. That's the whole trick of it.

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CHAPTER EIGHT

THE THAUMATURGICAL CONVERGENCE CHAMBER

Derek had followed the humming.

That was the honest sequence of events, the one he would later decline to put in any official account: he had heard a strange humming beneath the mansion, and instead of doing what fifteen years of corporate risk management had trained him to do, he'd found a flashlight and gone down toward it.

The basement corridor was old stone, older than the house had any right to be — older, in fact, than the state, which raised architectural questions Derek chose not to pursue past the first landing. The air down here had its own climate: cool, mineral, and humming, a vibration felt in the back teeth more than heard. His flashlight beam picked out copper pipes and modern fiber optic cables running side by side along the walls — and, alongside both, ceremonial markings carved into the stone itself, the plumbing and the prayers sharing a conduit. Whoever had built this place had seen no contradiction there. Whoever maintained it, apparently, still didn't.

The beam caught something reflective. A brass plate: ELECTRICAL CONTROL — 1952. And next to it, in the same municipal brass, the same stamped font, as though both had come from the same catalog: THAUMATURGICAL CONVERGENCE CHAMBER.

Derek touched the fiber optic cables. "This installation can't be from the fifties..."

From somewhere deeper came a whirring — the sound of massive hard drives spinning up, if hard drives came in cathedral sizes. The cables pulsed with light under his fingers.

"Hello? Mr. K?" a voice called. "You might want to see this..."

Derek followed the voice and found a man kneeling by an open panel — coveralls, toolbox, the unmistakable ease of someone who had been maintaining this building long enough to have stopped asking it questions. Larry Leland, then. The maintenance man Linda had mentioned, the keeper of the mansion's mechanical secrets, present in the basement without any car in the drive or knock at the door that Derek could account for — though at Ravenscrest, "how did you get in" was a question that had lost most of its explanatory power.

Inside the panel: circuit boards etched with strange symbols, pulsing with the same light as the cables.

"Never seen processing architecture like this," the man said. "Almost like it's growing..."

The lights flickered. Above them, a security camera swiveled, silently, to watch.

"You must be Larry — we've heard all about you," Derek said. "Growing how?"

"These circuits... they're not just processing. They're... evolving. If I had to use a biological analogy — it's like synapses connecting electronic nodes."

A distant thunderclap. Through a basement window, Derek saw Linda's Mercedes pulling away from the house, in more of a hurry than a realtor's car should ever be.

"We should head back up. My wife Nancy will be wondering what happened to me down here. But, Larry... let's keep this between us for now."

Larry closed the panel and stood. "Not sure everyone would understand the difference between real magic and sufficiently advanced technology."

They headed up the stairs, their footsteps fading.

Behind them, in the dark, the circuits pulsed again, and within the crystalline structure new patterns began to form — patiently, the way coral builds, the way ideas do.

The security camera turned to watch them leave. And in its lens, for just a moment, stood the reflection of two men side by side — Sam and Jonathan Rhodes — and then static.

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CHAPTER NINE

TWENTY-SEVEN MISSED CALLS

The late afternoon sun filtered through the Victorian windows of the study. Derek paced near the antique desk while Nancy sat cross-legged on their makeshift bed. The pipe organ's haunting rendition of "The Phantom of the Opera" — it had been milking the theme all afternoon — faded at last to silence.

Derek scrolled through his phone notifications with the expression of a man reading his own obituary. The old life had not, it turned out, stopped happening simply because he'd left it. It had continued without him at full volume, and every hour of it had been logged, time-stamped, and delivered to his pocket: the meetings missed, the emails flagged urgent, the little red numbers climbing their icons like ivy.

"Twenty-seven missed calls from Charles," he sighed. "I think that's a new record."

Nancy was looking at her own phone with a concern of her own. "Gee... Sophia's left twelve voicemails about the Anderson showing. Says the client's threatening to pull everything."

The phone in Derek's hand rang. Charles's face filled the screen, and even the photo looked stressed.

"Time to face the music," Derek said to Nancy, and answered. "Charles, I—"

"Three days!" Charles's voice came through the phone at a volume that made holding it to the ear optional. "Three days of radio silence after our last brief chat. What's going on with you, Derek? This is so not you. First the boardroom meltdown, complete with a really crazy impersonation of your dead Uncle Sam, and me

having to deal with the Board... God, I need a breakdown, not you."

"I am truly sorry, Charles, but that has been brewing in me for a long time. I guess the cork finally popped."

"Popped?!... You call that POPPED!"

"Okay, maybe a deep psychotic break. But it wasn't that bad."

"Well, thanks, buddy, but my ass is in some hot water right now and I truly need your help. Just help me with the Jacobson account, and after that we can figure out your proper exit plan. After all, you have ten percent of the shares in this place."

In the mirror on the wall, Sam appeared behind Derek — silently mocking, mouthing *Oh oh ohhhh!* with theatrical relish at the phrase *exit plan*.

"Well, for the record, Charles, I just bought an old mansion about two hours north of you, which I hope to turn into a cool inn and B\&B. Maybe add a comedy club, or a spa. Still in the development stages."

"Great — I need a change of scenery, and we need to meet face-to-face. I am on my way. Text me your address."

The lights flickered. In the mirror, Sam's reflection made an offended face, the face of a headliner informed that a PowerPoint would be opening for him.

"I need a few days to sort things out," Derek said. "Maybe work remotely, then have you come up—"

"Remote work? Sorry, buddy, we are in crisis here. So here's getting back at you this time... text the address." And Charles hung up before Derek could respond.

Derek stared at his phone.

Nancy was just finishing her own call. "Well, Sophia's marginally less homicidal than your boss."

"Charles is coming up! Just what we need now!"

Thunder rumbled outside. The sky, as ever, was clear; the house simply enjoyed punctuation. And in an antique armchair by the window, Sam materialized, one leg draped over the armrest, entirely at home.

"Oh oh ohhhh! You've got bigger problems than some stuffed shirt and his PowerPoint addiction, kid! We've got a show to prepare!"

Derek — who on some level still believed he was imagining these conversations with his dead uncle, and had decided the belief was load-bearing — answered out loud anyway. "A show I know nothing about! I need time—"

"Time? I died after doing that set! The least you could do is learn it!"

"Who — you talking to?" Nancy asked.

"My stupid imagination, I guess."

—

Across town, the office of Coastal Dreams Realty kept its usual immaculate face to the street — the window display of listings, the tasteful ferns, the framed SALESPERSON OF THE YEAR certificates marching along one wall in an unbroken line that went back further than the certificates' fonts should have allowed. Inside, Linda Rhodes sat at her desk with a phone against her ear and her voice at its most carefully managed — the voice she used for difficult closings, for buyers on the edge, for anyone who needed to be walked gently back from a ledge only she could see.

"I told you earlier that this is what they said had to happen... I know what we want, but we need to follow protocol, or we risk losing everything... I know you're mad... I know you're—" She closed her eyes. "Wait. There's no need for you to go and do that... Give me

a few days and let me see what I can do... Thank you."

She hung up, breathed once, and dialed another number. When she spoke again, her voice had transformed — warm, confiding, a bottle of wine uncorked over the phone line.

"Hi, Marina, it's Linda Rhodes. I had an interesting chat with Chad, and I think we need to talk face-to-face. I don't feel comfortable doing what he is asking of me, and — being of the female gender — I am offended he would make such outlandish claims about you. It's entirely up to you, but I could clear my schedule later today and we could meet over a couple drinks and perhaps a bite to eat. Would you have any interest in driving out here later today?"

A pause, while somewhere in Los Angeles an influencer weighed her options.

"Well, Marina, I really prefer chatting about this face-to-face. Who knows who may be listening in on my calls these days..." A beat, and then the warmth redoubled. "Great. I know you will not regret meeting with me. See you in a few hours... Let's keep our little meeting secret. We don't want anyone else getting into the mix, do we... Great. Safe drive."

Linda put the phone down, and for a moment she simply sat there, both hands flat on the desk, the salesperson-of-the-year smile draining out of her face like water finding a crack. Whatever she had just done — and she had done it beautifully, warmly, with offense taken on Marina's behalf and secrecy proposed as a courtesy — it sat in the office with her now, and it was heavy.

She reached behind the desk for a decanter of scotch, poured herself a large glass of booze, and took a big gulp. She leaned back in the chair.

Her hair fell off.

It landed on the desk with the soft finality of a curtain, and Linda Rhodes sat bald in the afternoon light, two small bumps — or perhaps horn stumps — protruding slightly from her skull.

She took another big gulp.

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CHAPTER TEN

AN EFFECTIVE TEAM

Late afternoon found them back in the study, where all of Ravenscrest's important conversations seemed to gravitate, the way water finds the low point of a field. The light through the Victorian windows had gone long and honeyed, and it lay across the antique desk, the makeshift bed, the two phones face-down like a truce.

Nancy had been circling something for an hour, and Derek could tell, because after ten years of marriage you learn the shape of your wife's thinking before she says it out loud. She folded things that didn't need folding. She checked her phone and put it down without reading it. She looked at the door to San Francisco — which was, technically, every door — and then didn't look at it, which was somehow louder.

"Maybe I could go back alone?" she said finally. "Handle the gallery, check on the house..."

In the armchair, Sam considered this option. His face — the mobile, weathered, expressive instrument that had once made rooms full of strangers weep with laughter — went still and thoughtful, and for a moment the room got to see something audiences rarely had: the comedian between bits, the machinery at rest, weighing a real question about real people.

"The lady's got a point," he said. "You need to focus, kid. That council isn't known for their patience."

"Great," Derek said, "and leave me here to deal with Charles and all this crazy shit?"

Sam laughed. "Job? Kid, you're a Kinison! We don't do spreadsheets — we do SHOWBUSINESS!"

The pipe organ played a quick "ta-da" riff, right on the button. The house had impeccable comic timing. It was, Derek reflected, possibly the only thing in his life right now that did.

"I'll take care of everything in San Francisco," Nancy said. "Two days, tops. I will bring you back some clothes, and that should get us through to after the whole town hall crap."

And then Nancy Hammond did something she had never done before in the entire run of their marriage: she did an impression. She squared her shoulders, dropped her voice into movie-trailer register, and delivered the line from *Oblivion*:

"Are we an effective team?"

Derek smiled at her — the real smile, the one from before the mortgage and the meltdown. "Maybe you should do the act. After all, you're technically a Kinison. Nobody said anything about gender?"

Nancy tilted her head, exactly the way Sam would, exactly the way she had now seen him do in two mirrors and one bathroom, and said: "I just became a Hammond again... OH... OH... OHHHHHHH!"

Then she collapsed into an uncontrolled laugh, the kind that takes the whole body hostage.

"Wow," came Sam's voice from everywhere and nowhere, rich with something that in a living man would have been pride. "Now I think I love this girl. She's a keeper, Junior."

Nancy recovered, wiping her eye. "We need to think positive. Besides, somebody needs to make sure our house doesn't end up as haunted as this one."

"Hey!" Sam said. "I prefer 'spiritually enhanced.'"

Derek sat down on the edge of the bed. The day's weight arrived all at once, the way it does. "Do you think maybe we should just

leave and go back to our old lives? They were much simpler. Although I may need to find another job after my little meltdown."

"Hey." Nancy crossed to him. "Where is 'Mr. Glass Half Full guy' I married? Besides, after what we just had to go through — game on, babe."

Derek deployed the poor-me voice, the one that had never once worked on her and that he maintained anyway out of tradition. "But I will have to sleep here all alone in this big scary haunted mansion, and you're going to be dining with Sophia on sushi at Ju-Ni while I will be eating mac and cheese with the spirit of Sam."

"Maybe you can have a personal séance," Nancy said, trying to be a little playful, "and conjure up the ghost of Farrah Fawcett to keep you company while I'm away. You always had a thing for her, didn't you?"

"Well, maybe that could help," Derek said, doing his best to keep up, "but I think I may also need to include Tanya Roberts, to be fair."

Nancy had started packing up her stuff. "Well, if you're going that far, why not bring back Princess Leia for the perfect trifecta?"

"Come on, honey, you know that you are all I need, whether you're here or not. Besides, there is no way I would ever trust Sam with those gals in the house."

Nancy and Derek exchanged a look — the long, married look that says, without a syllable, *I think we've exhausted that joke*.

Nancy finished packing while Derek sat down at the antique desk and opened his laptop. He watched the wifi icon search, and search, and give up — which was rich, he thought, in a house whose basement was running processing architecture that made Larry Leland use the word *evolving*. The mansion had bandwidth. The mansion simply wasn't sharing.

"No signal. How am I supposed to research his final set?"

"Research?" Sam appeared behind Derek. "Oh no, kid. We're doing this the old-fashioned way."

The dumb waiter dinged.

Derek looked at Nancy. Nancy looked at Derek. The dumb waiter, having made its point, blinked its small red light in patient invitation.

Derek walked over and opened it, and inside, sitting alone on the tray where that morning there had been coffee and scones and a rose, was an ancient VHS tape. Black plastic gone gray at the corners, the little window showing spooled ribbon, the whole object radiating that specific obsolescence of technology that once ruled the world. The label, in faded ink, read: "The Last Show — 4/9/92."

The date sat on the label doing quiet arithmetic. April 9, 1992. The stage in town. The night before the world said his uncle died.

"That looks like the tape you found the other night, Nancy," Derek said, picking it up and inspecting it closely — turning it over, as though the other side of a VHS tape had ever told anyone anything.

"How the hell did it end up in the dumb waiter?" Nancy asked. Derek shrugged his shoulders while looking at her, a gesture that was becoming his primary form of communication at Ravenscrest. "Now you need to find some ancient VHS player," she added, with a smirk and raised eyebrows. "Just call out and ask Sam."

—

By early evening, the study had rearranged itself for a screening.

Derek sat at the antique desk with the VHS tape before him. Nancy continued packing in the background, folding with the brisk efficiency of a woman who intended to be on the road within the hour and back within forty-eight. And on a side table where, that

afternoon, there had been nothing at all, an old TV/VCR combo unit had appeared — mysteriously, silently, complete with its little rabbit-ear antenna, as though it had been there since the Eisenhower administration and everyone had simply failed to notice.

Derek regarded it.

"Well," he said, "that's convenient."

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CHAPTER ELEVEN

SOME SHOWS AREN'T MEANT TO BE RERUN

He inserted the tape.

The machine took it with a mechanical swallow, gears engaging somewhere in its ancient interior, and Derek realized he was holding his breath. This was, if the label could be trusted, the last show. The set the council wanted from him, word for word. The night the world's account of his uncle's death began to be wrong. Everything he needed was on this ribbon of magnetized plastic, and all he had to do was watch it.

Static filled the little screen, that gray-white snow that an entire generation once fell asleep to, and then the image stabilized — and Derek's breath caught, because he was looking at the Town Hall stage. The same stage he had stood before that morning. The same single microphone in the same spotlight. The date stamp in the corner read: *April 9, 1992*.

Sam took the stage.

Derek leaned in. Somewhere behind him, Nancy had stopped packing.

But something was off. Derek felt it before he could name it, the way you feel a wrong note before you know which instrument played it. The audience. The audience was wrong. They weren't in black formal wear, or Friday-night denim, or anything an audience wears.

They were dressed in ceremonial robes.

Every one of them, rows and rows into the dark of the theatre, hooded and still, watching the stage the way congregations watch an altar. And at the edge of the frame, beside the stage, stood two figures Derek recognized with a jolt: Mayor Blackwood — thirty-some years younger, unmistakably her — standing beside Jonathan Rhodes.

Rhodes turned toward the camera, or toward whoever held it, and spoke — a voice flattened by three decades of magnetic tape:

"Integration test forty-seven. Subject: Samuel Kinison. Quantum consciousness transfer initiating..."

Every electronic device in the study activated simultaneously.

Derek's laptop snapped awake. His phone lit up in his pocket. Even the antique radio in the corner — a piece of furniture, a decoration, a thing that possibly had no cord — hummed to life. And every screen, every display, every glowing surface in the room showed the same two words:

PLAYBACK TERMINATED.

The VHS tape ejected violently — not the polite mechanical push of a machine finishing its job, but a rejection, the tape leaping from the slot as though the player had spat it out. Derek caught it, fumbled it, caught it again. He turned it over in his hands. The label still read what it read. He pushed it back in.

Static. Then a laugh track. Then, in glorious black and white, Lucille Ball wrapping chocolates on a conveyor belt.

The tape had been replaced — inside the machine, inside the same cassette, inside whatever rules still applied — with an episode of *I Love Lucy*.

And through the static under the laugh track, close and quiet as a hand on the shoulder, came Sam's voice:

"Some shows aren't meant to be rerun, kid."

"Derek..." Nancy had been watching, and her voice had gone very careful. "What just happened?"

Before he could answer — before he could even begin to inventory what an answer would need to contain — his phone rang.

He looked at the display. He looked at it for a while.

"You're not going to believe who is calling."

"Who?"

"It says *Dr. Blackwood*."

Nancy came around the desk to see for herself. "Maybe he has a grandson who's a doctor," she said, and then, in the interest of accuracy: "To be fair to my sex — maybe a granddaughter."

"Should I answer it?"

"It can't get any weirder than it is. Can it?"

Derek gave her the raised-eyebrow, wide-eyed stare — the one that said *we both know that was a rhetorical question and we both know the answer* — and picked up.

"Derek Kinison here."

The voice on the other end was anxious, hurried, thin as if traveling much farther than a phone call should. "Mr. Kinison — whatever you do, don't try to watch that tape. The Council... there are things about that night... about your uncle's last show..."

The call broke apart into static.

And through the study window, headlights swept the drive: Linda's Mercedes, speeding away from the mansion, gravel spraying, in the unambiguous body language of a car whose driver had seen enough.

Derek lowered the phone slowly.

Dr. Blackwood. A man whose portrait hung in this house. A man who — if Earl's account held — had been found dead in a study very much like this one, by a granddaughter, and buried in a coffin that later proved to be empty. That man's name had just lit up a phone screen in the year 2025 to deliver a warning about a videotape.

Derek had spent fifteen years building risk models. Not one of them had a column for this.

"Nancy, I think you should delay your trip. Something tells me we're going to need each other for whatever comes next."

"What did the caller want?"

"It was a warning. *Whatever you do, don't try to watch that tape. The Council... there are things about that night... about your uncle's last show...*"

Nancy took this in the way she had taken in everything since the moans in the walls — with a resilience Derek was coming to regard as the eighth wonder of the world.

"Now *that* is weird," she conceded. "But I am sure you will be fine. Two days. What's the worst that could happen — I find you strung up in the foyer with a red pentagram symbol carved into your chest?" She gave him the look. The *two can play that game* look.

"Worse," Derek said. "You could return and find me in the company of a bevy of gorgeous vampire women that feed on me each night... and then do other unspeakable things to me, over, and..."

"Ha. Ha." She turned back to her bag. "It will give you time to do some more exploring of the mansion. Maybe take a walk into town. And don't forget — there's that quaint little lake just out of town. You could buy a rod and tackle from Earl and see what's in it."

"You're probably right. It will give me some time to explore. Not sure Old Grumpy will want to do anything except work on the Jacobson deal."

"Moderation, babe. Moderation. After all, you are in the country now." She zipped the bag. "Walk me to the car. I can be home by ten if I leave now."

And there it was — the plan, restated, unbudged. Derek looked at his wife and recognized the posture: Nancy Hammond had run the numbers, and the numbers said the gallery needed two days and the mansion needed a week, and a woman who had once talked a Rothschild-adjacent client off a cliff over speakerphone was not going to be rerouted by one anonymous warning and a haunted VCR. He loved her for it. He was also, in a low and steady way he didn't say out loud, afraid — not of the house, exactly. Of the arithmetic. Of two people who were stronger together being, for two days, apart.

Thunder crashed.

Not rumbled — crashed, close and sudden, the loudest the house had spoken all day. And in the dark screen of the TV, in its curved reflection where the study should have been, stood two figures side by side: Sam and Jonathan Rhodes, both wearing ceremonial robes, both looking — and this was the part that dried Derek's mouth — *concerned*. Whatever these two knew, whatever they had been through together on a stage in 1992, it worried them. And things that worried the dead were, Derek felt strongly, things that should worry everyone.

They spoke in unison, two voices braided into one:

"It's happening again..."

The power went out.

Not a flicker, not a brownout, not the polite dimming of a grid under strain — the house simply closed its eyes. The study plunged into darkness, total, velvet, absolute, except for the fiber optic cables in the walls, which continued to pulse with their strange light, veins of the house glowing faintly through the plaster, keeping whatever time they kept. The pulses came slow and regular, and in the black they were the only movement in the world, and Derek understood, watching them, that the electricity was gone but the house was not off. The house was never off. The house was, at most, choosing what to spend itself on.

And from somewhere in the dark, bright as a marquee:

"Hope you like role-playing games!"

Derek found an old candelabra by feel, found the matchbox beside it, and struck a light. The candle flames caught, steadied, and made a small warm island of the two of them. Holding the candelabra aloft like a man auditioning for a gothic novel, Derek led Nancy down the staircase toward the main foyer.

And in the mirrors that adorned the staircase walls — mirror after mirror after mirror, the house's favorite gallery — the usual motley group of comedians kept pace with them, candlelit faces sliding from frame to frame the way they always did.

Except tonight the comedians were not laughing, not mugging, not performing. Tonight, every one of them was dressed in odd robes. No pratfalls. No bits. Not one of them worked the room, and a comedian who won't work the room is a thing more unsettling than any moan in any wall.

Every one of them looked worried.

Derek walked his wife down the stairs through a gauntlet of anxious dead entertainers, the candelabra throwing its small ring of light, and understood — in the wordless way the house preferred to communicate — that whatever was coming, the audience on the

other side of the glass had seen it before.

—

Somewhere else — below somewhere, behind somewhere, in a part of the world that did not appear on the county's surveyor maps — someone was looking out through their own eyes.

The view came in blinks, slow and heavy, the blinks of someone surfacing from a depth. A small window. Through it: a large medieval basement, stone-vaulted, lit by fire, the flames throwing shadows that climbed the walls and would not stay still. In the middle of the chamber stood what could only be called an altar — a large one, ancient, purposeful — and around it, wearing strange robes, moving through the deliberate choreography of a ritual, was the town council. The same faces that had presided from a theatre box that morning. The gavel hand. The top hat, exchanged now for a hood.

Blink.

On the altar lay a woman, tied. From the altar's center rose a single golden pole, and atop the pole sat a cube — glowing, blue, patient.

Blink.

The woman wore a white dress. On her head sat a strange-looking helmet. And as she slowly turned her face toward the small window, toward the eyes doing the watching, the firelight found her features.

It was Marina.

The LA buyer. The internet influencer. Three million views and counting — the woman who, a few hours earlier, had accepted an invitation to drinks, a bite to eat, and a little secret meeting, because who knows who may be listening in on the calls these days.

Her mouth opened.

Darkness.

END OF BOOK THREE



Here's the thing about warnings, kid. Everybody gets one. The phone rings, the tape ejects, the mirror fogs over and writes you a little note — the universe is not subtle. The trick isn't hearing the warning. The trick is figuring out which show it's trying to cancel... yours, or somebody else's.

OH OH OHHHH!

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

Living With the Ghost of Sam is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

The Last Axiom (Books 1–15)

A Letter Guide for Rebecca